

# The Studio Sessions

The music producer  
took my girlfriend

Evan Slate



# THE STUDIO SESSIONS

I sat behind the glass while the music  
producer took my girlfriend

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**PMI**

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Brooke brought it up over breakfast on a Saturday, the kind of lazy morning with us both still in our pajamas, sunlight coming through the kitchen window of our tiny apartment.

"I've been thinking about something," she said, poking at her eggs with her fork. She wasn't looking at me, which meant she was nervous about whatever she was going to say.

"Yeah?" I said, looking up from my phone.

"About singing again. Like, actually trying to do something with it this time. Not just singing along in my car."

I put my phone down and gave her my full attention. Brooke had a beautiful voice, something I'd been telling her since we started dating two years ago, but she'd always been too shy to do anything with it, too worried about being judged or failing or putting herself out there.

"It's a great idea," I said. "What made you start thinking about that?"

She shrugged, still not quite meeting my eyes. "I don't know. I just feel like if I don't try now, I never will. I'm twenty-three, you know? It feels like now or never."

"So what would you want to do? Like, perform? Record?"

"I don't even know where to start," she said. "That's the problem. I don't know the first thing about actually pursuing it."

I thought for a moment, trying to remember if I knew anyone in music, and then it came to me. Kai, a guy I'd known in college, not well, but we'd been friendly, talking about beats and productions and artists I'd never heard of. I'd seen on Instagram recently that he'd opened a studio somewhere.

"I might know someone, actually," I said. "Guy from college, Kai. He was really into music production, always had recording equipment in his dorm room. I saw on Instagram he has a studio now."

Brooke's eyes lit up, that hopeful expression that made me want to help her, made me want to really make this happen for her.

"Really? Do you think he'd talk to me?"

"I can reach out. See if he'd be willing to meet up, at least."

I pulled out my phone and found Kai's Instagram, scrolled through photos of studio equipment and artists I didn't recognize, and sent him a DM. I kept it casual, said my girlfriend was interested in recording, asked if he'd be willing to meet up and talk to her about it, drinks on me.

The response came back within ten minutes, three bubbles appearing and then his message: "Yo Terrance! Been a minute man. Yeah absolutely, would love to meet her. I just got this new space set up, still getting it dialed in, but it's coming together. You guys free this week? There's a cafe near the studio, we could grab coffee there."

We set it up for Thursday afternoon. Kai sent me the name of the cafe.

Thursday came and I drove us downtown, following GPS to a part of the city we never went to, a neighborhood that looked pretty rough for Brooke and me. The buildings got older and more industrial as we went, graffiti covering walls and roll-down security gates, groups of people hanging out on corners.

"This is the place?" Brooke asked. I could hear the nervousness in her voice.

"I guess so," I said, checking the map again.

I found parking on a street that made me double-check I'd locked the car. We walked a block to the cafe Kai had suggested. It was called Reverb, painted matte black with a bright mural of sound waves in neon colors across the front, young people sitting at outdoor tables despite the autumn chill, everyone looking cooler and more alternative than we looked in our casual attire.

Inside was dim and crowded, exposed brick and vintage band posters, the smell of coffee and something sweet baking, indie music playing a bit too loud. Kai was already there, sitting at a table near the window, and when he saw us, he waved.

He looked different than I remembered but also exactly the same, older but with that same easy confidence, in dark jeans and a faded band t-shirt, great haircut, the kind of presence that made him seem comfortable anywhere.

"Terrance," he said, pulling me into a quick hug with a hand clasp. "Man, good to see you. Been what, five years?"

"About that," I said. "This is Brooke."

"Hey," Kai said, extending his hand to her with a warm smile. "Terrance says you want to get into the music biz!"

Brooke shook his hand and immediately looked down, that shy thing she did when she was nervous. "I mean, yeah, but not professionally or anything. Just for fun."

"That's cool too," Kai said, gesturing for us to sit. "Everyone starts somewhere. What kind of stuff do you like? What artists you into?"

We sat down and ordered coffee. Kai asked Brooke questions about her musical taste, what drew her to singing, what she listened to. He was good at drawing her out, asking follow-up questions, making her feel like her answers were heard. I watched her start to relax, start to open up a little. She watched him when he wasn't looking. I could tell she found him interesting. He was like nobody she had in her life.

The cafe itself felt rough and ready in a way our life didn't, all these people who seemed like "the creatives." Kai clearly belonged here. He knew the barista by name, nodded at a couple people who came in, made jokes with others. Brooke laughed at something he said that I knew she didn't get. She was constantly twirling her hair to the point I was going to make a joke to her about it.

"Well I'd love to hear you sing," Kai said after we'd been talking for maybe twenty minutes. "Get a sense of who this is," he said, and he smirked at me. Brooke blushed.

"I don't know if I belong in a real studio," Brooke said sheepishly.

"There's no not belonging," Kai said. "It's about finding you are, developing your identity. That's what studios really do." He checked his phone. "Actually, studio's got free time right now if you want to come up and check the space out."

Brooke looked at me and I nodded. I paid for coffee and we followed Kai out onto the street.

The neighborhood felt even rougher walking through it, chain-link fences and closed storefronts and people hanging out who watched us pass with expressions like they were all getting a read on us, especially Brooke who was definitely overdressed. I felt out of place too and on edge, but Kai walked like he belonged, relaxed and confident, and a couple people even called out to him by name, "Hey Kai." He raised his chin subtly in response.

We walked three blocks to an old brick warehouse building, four stories tall with big industrial windows. Kai punched a code into a keypad next to a heavy metal door and held it open for us.

Inside was a stairwell that smelled like old wood and concrete, dim lighting and exposed pipes. We followed Kai up to the second floor. The hallway was industrial and minimal, all bricks and beams. Kai unlocked another door and led us into his studio.

The space made me catch my breath. It was a half-converted warehouse loft, maybe fifteen hundred square feet, raw brick walls and original wood beams and high ceilings that must have been twenty feet up. One section had been built out into a proper recording studio with soundproofed walls, and through a large window, I could see into the booth, all brick and warm lighting and a vintage microphone.

The control room had a serious mixing board that looked expensive, multiple computer monitors, speakers on stands, and one big gaming chair positioned behind the board where you could see through the glass into the recording booth.

"This is incredible," Brooke said, looking around with wide eyes.

"Yeah," Kai said. I could tell he was pleased with himself. "It's taken me a couple years to get it here, but it's finally starting to feel right."

He showed us around, explaining the equipment, letting Brooke touch the microphone in the booth, showing her how the headphones worked. He was patient and clear, making everything seem accessible.

Inside the booth I could see a leather couch against one wall, a brick backdrop, a vintage mic on its stand, soft lighting that made the space feel intimate and professional at the same time.

"So when we're recording," Kai said, pointing to a red light mounted above the booth door, "that light goes on. There's only one rule in every sound studio: if that light is on, you don't open the door. Mic is live. No matter what you see or hear going on in there, you wait until the light goes off. And I control when it goes on and off," he chuckled.

I nodded, filing it away as an important technical thing to remember if we ever came back, which I wasn't sure we would.

"I'd love to have you go on in and just try out some stuff," Kai said to Brooke. "No pressure, just see how it feels for you. See if we click creatively, you know?"

"Just come down here and sing you mean?" Brooke asked.

"We'll just see if we vibe, producer and artist. And to be honest, I'm building my own portfolio out, I'm working with different voices, so it's valuable work for me too."

Brooke looked at me again and I smiled and said, "You should do it. This is an amazing opportunity."

"I don't know if I have a voice," she said, using air quotes. I knew she was beaming inside about being called an artist.

"Everyone has a voice. You'll find yours, too," Kai said.

We set up a session for the following week, thanked Kai, and walked back through the neighborhood to our car. Once we were inside with the doors locked I started the engine and Brooke immediately grabbed my hand.

"Thank you, thank you!" she said. "For setting this up. For encouraging me to do it!"

"Of course," I said. "I'm excited for you. Kai seems really cool, really professional. I think this could be really good for you."

We drove back and she talked the whole way, excited and nervous at the same time. I felt good about it, felt like I'd done something right by connecting her with him. It was supportive of me. I was as excited about what could come of it as much as she was.

She was going to work with a real producer in a real studio, and I'd helped make it happen.

That night she was overly affectionate in bed. I fell asleep feeling like a good partner, like someone who encouraged his girlfriend's dreams instead of holding her back. I was filled with anticipation of what would happen in that studio.

A week later I drove us downtown for the session, Brooke in the passenger seat checking her reflection in the visor mirror, this after changing her outfit three times before we'd left the apartment.

"You look great," I said. "Just relax. It's going to be fine."

"I know," she said, flipping the visor back up. "I'm just nervous. What if I'm awful? What if he realizes I have no idea what I'm doing?"

"Then he'll teach you. That's literally the whole point of this."

I navigated to the neighborhood we'd visited the week before. Brooke stayed quiet, looking out the window. I could feel her anxiety.

We parked on the street and walked quickly to the warehouse building, Brooke staying close to me. I punched in the code Kai had given me and we



climbed the stairs to the second floor.

Kai was waiting at the studio door, casual in jeans and a hoodie, coffee in hand. He greeted us with that same easy warmth from the cafe, and handed us each coffees that he got for us.

"So hey, Brooke, you think you're ready to try this?" he asked Brooke.

"I guess so," she said, her voice small.

"No pressure," he said, unlocking the door and gesturing us inside. "This is just about getting comfortable, seeing how it feels for you. Inside like."

The studio looked even better than I remembered, afternoon light flowing through the tall windows, all the equipment clean and professional, the whole space radiating creative possibility.

Kai led Brooke to the booth, opened the heavy soundproof door, and showed her inside. I watched through the control room window as he adjusted the microphone stand to her height, showed her how to position herself, how to hold the headphones.

"These let you hear yourself and any backing track I play," he explained. "I'll be out there at the board. I can talk to you through this speaker. You can talk back to me and I'll hear you through this mic."

The booth looked small and intimate from where I stood, maybe eight feet by ten feet, with the brick wall as backdrop, the vintage mic in the center, and that small leather couch against the side wall. The lighting was warm and inviting.

"Terrance, you can sit out here," Kai said, gesturing to the control room.

I sat in the big gaming chair behind the mixing board. The space between the board and the glass was tight, enough room for the chair and maybe one person standing. Through the window I had a perfect view of Brooke in the booth. I could see her looking small and uncertain at the microphone, approaching it like some creature.

Kai sat at the board next to me, adjusted some controls, and he pressed a button that made his voice come through a speaker in the booth.

"Okay Brooke, let's start with some warmups. Just scales to get your voice ready. I'll play you some notes, you just follow along."

He played notes on the keyboard and she sang along, tentative and quietly. I could hear her voice through the monitors in the control room. It was pretty but restricted, like she was afraid of being too loud. I knew she was better.

They did scales for maybe ten minutes, Kai patient and encouraging through the talkback. Then he asked her to sing something she knew well, anything she was comfortable with.

She chose a song I'd heard her sing in the car dozens of times. But it sounded different here, more self-conscious and careful. Her voice was nice but it was stiff and nervous, all the natural ease she had singing to herself completely gone.

Kai had her try a few different songs, different approaches, always encouraging her. I could tell he was trying to figure out how to get her to relax, to find that ease she clearly had somewhere inside her.

After about thirty minutes in he muted the talkback and turned to me in the chair.

"She's got something real," he said quietly. "Good tone, nice control, interesting quality. But she's completely locked up. She's too much in her head. She needs to get out of her own way."

"How do you do that?" I asked.

"I say physical techniques. Breathing exercises, total body awareness, relaxation stuff. Singing is really physical, it's all about the body, most people don't realize that." He paused. "Are you cool if I worked with her on some of that? Like hands-on stuff, teaching her proper breath support, how to release tension? It can get pretty physical."

"Yeah, of course," I said. "Whatever helps her."

Kai nodded and pressed the talkback button.

"Brooke, I'm going to come in there and work with you on some breathing techniques, okay? It'll help you relax, help you access more of your voice."

"Okay," her voice came through the speaker, small and uncertain.

Kai went into the booth, and the red light above the door clicked on. I watched through the glass as he closed the door behind him and approached Brooke at the microphone.

He stood close to her, maybe a foot away, and placed his hands on her ribcage below her chest.

"Breathe deep," he said. I could hear him through the monitors. "Not from your chest, from your diaphragm. Feel it expand here."

His hands pressed gently against her sides as she breathed in. I watched her chest rise and fall, watched his hands move with her breathing.

"Good. Again, deeper this time. Really fill up from the bottom."

She breathed in again and his hands followed the movement of her ribs. One hand moved to her lower back, pressing her there at the same time.

"Feel how the breath supports you from your whole core? It's not just your lungs, it's your back, your sides, everything working together."

He kept her breathing slowly like that for several minutes, his hands pressing gently on her ribs and her back, adjusting her posture. It was professional and instructional but undeniably physical too. I watched through the glass as Brooke's whole body language changed under his touch.

Her shoulders dropped. Her jaw unclenched. Her posture opened up.

"Better," Kai said. "Much better. Now let's try that song again, but keep this breathing. Don't think about singing, just focus on the breath."

He stepped back and she sang, and the difference was immediate and dramatic. Her voice was fuller, more relaxed, more open. She sounded better than I'd ever heard her singing in the car or the shower.

Kai came back to the control room and the red light clicked off as he closed the booth door behind him. We sat together and listened through the monitors as Brooke sang the whole song through, and when she finished he pressed the talkback.

"That was great. Hear the difference?"

"Yeah," Brooke said. I could see her smiling through the glass. "That felt completely different. So much much right in here," she said, feeling her own abdomen.

They worked for another thirty minutes, Kai going in and out of the booth to adjust her breathing or her posture, always hands-on, and by the end of the session, Brooke's voice had completely transformed, sounding confident and full in a way it hadn't at all at the beginning.

When we finally packed up to leave, Brooke was energized in a way I rarely saw her, practically bouncing as we walked to the car, talking rapidly about everything she'd learned. Gone was the fear or even the awareness of the neighborhood.

"That breathing thing, it's insane how much difference it makes," she said as I drove us out of the neighborhood toward the highway. "I could actually feel it working. And Kai is so good, he really knows how to do things, like physical things."

"Yeah, he seems great," I said. And I meant it. "Really professional."

"I learned more in two hours than I would have figured out on my own in years," she said.

That night at home Brooke was more affectionate than usual, more physically present. She initiated a kiss in the kitchen while I was making dinner, stayed close to me on the couch while we watched TV, her hand finding mine. It was like she was more in her body than before.

When we went to bed she was more engaged during sex, too, more expressive, making more sound than she usually made, her body moving with mine in a way that felt different and more connected.

I noticed it but I didn't connect it to the session. I just thought she was in a good mood, I thought the confidence from learning something new and doing well at it was carrying over into other parts of her life.

The second session was the following week, the same routine already establishing itself. I drove us downtown through the neighborhood that still made me nervous, parked on the street, walked quickly to the warehouse.

Kai greeted us at the studio door with coffee again. We went through what was becoming familiar, Brooke heading into the booth while I settled into the gaming chair behind the mixing board.

"Today I want to focus even more on the physical," Kai said, adjusting levels on the board. "Really getting her connected to where the sound comes from in her body."

He reached over and hit record on the computer. I watched the waveforms start moving on the screen.

"I want to keep it running the whole session," he explained. "You never know when you're going to catch something magic, some unexpected moment that's worth keeping."

He went into the booth and the red light clicked on above the door.

I watched through the glass as Kai had Brooke do some warmup scales, and then he stepped close to her, closer than he'd was last session, and put his ear against her chest right at her sternum.

"Sing this note," he said. I heard his voice through the monitors in the control room.

She sang and he listened with his ear pressed to her chest, his hand coming up to rest on her back for balance. Brooke was eyeing me through the glass. I grinned at her and we both nearly started laughing.

"I'm listening for the resonance," he said, pulling back. "The vibration in your chest cavity. That's where a lot of the power comes from. Do it again."

She sang and he leaned in again, his ear against her sternum, his hand firm on her back. I sat in the control room watching this, now feeling something uncomfortable twist in my stomach as Brooke let her eyes close as she held her tone.

It looked professional. Clinical, even. This is how vocal coaches work, I said to myself. It's all about the physical.

They did exercises like that for maybe twenty minutes, Kai standing close to her, sometimes with his ear to her chest, sometimes with his hands on her ribs, monitoring how she breathed, and sometimes with his hand on her lower back or her stomach, checking her diaphragm movement.

"The voice really comes from here," he said, his hand sliding lower over her abdomen just above her hips. "Not from your throat, not even really from your chest. From your core. You have to learn to feel your here. You don't hear your voice here," he said, tickling her ear, surprising her, making her blush and smirk.

His hands moved all over her body with confidence. Brooke seemed to be responding to him, her breathing deepening, her posture improving.

Then Kai had her stand facing him, close.

"Now I want to monitor everything at once," he said. "Your breath, your jaw, your posture, your abdomen. So just sing and let me work with your body."

She started singing scales and he watched her face intently. Then his hands came up to her jaw, his fingers pressing gently into the muscles there.

"You're holding tension here," he said. "Feel that? You're clenching without realizing it. It's restricting your sound."

His fingers massaged her jaw muscles, working into the tissue. I watched through the glass as Brooke's eyes closed, her face relaxing under his touch.

"There you go," Kai said quietly. "Let it all go. Don't hold anything inside you."

His hands stayed on her jaw for maybe thirty seconds, working the muscles, before then they moved down to her neck, her shoulders, back to her ribs, down to her diaphragm, then her hips, constantly moving and adjusting her. She stumbled forward a moment and caught herself, her hands grabbing his hips, and she chuckled.

"It feels good," she murmured, not opening her eyes.

"It does, doesn't it," he murmured back.



“Mm-hmm!” Brooke said with a widening grin.

He caught my eye through the glass and gave me a thumbs up, a gesture that said this is working, she's improving, we're making progress. I nodded back, trying to ignore the uncomfortable feeling growing in my chest.

The session continued like that for the full hour, Kai's hands constantly moving over Brooke's body in some way, her jaw, her neck, her shoulders, her ribs, her lower back, her stomach, her hips, all of it framed as technical instruction, all of it about accessing different parts of the physical “instrument” that was her body.

And it was working, too. The vocal takes she produced sounded even better than last week, fuller and more controlled, more confident. She was opening up for him. I thought it was good.

When the session ended and we were back in the car driving home, Brooke talked wildly about how much more comfortable she felt with him, how his hands-on approach really helped her understand what he was explaining, made her, she said, “feel my body.”

"It makes so much sense when you can actually feel him touching wherever," she said. "Like, he'll tell me the breath comes from my core, but when he put his hand right on me there and I can feel where he means, it totally clicks."

"Yeah," I said, navigating onto the highway. "He's definitely a good teacher that way."

"We exchanged numbers," she told me. "He said so we can share ideas like whenever they come up, like with texting."

"Oh yeah, I didn't notice that."

"You're okay with me texting him, right?"

"Sure."

"He's good for me, thank you for finding him for me."

"If he's good for you."

"Yeah, and he's so professional about it, too, right?" she added. "Like, I know it's weird having someone touching you that much, but he makes it feel completely normal, just part of the process."

"That's good," I said.

That night Brooke initiated sex, which was unusual. Normally I was the one who started things. She came to bed where I was already reading and kissed me, her hands immediately going under my sweatpants.

She was more engaged than normal, more present in her body, more responsive to my touch, making sounds and moving in ways she typically didn't.

And then she went down on me, something she did maybe once every few months if that, took me in her mouth with an enthusiasm I hadn't seen from her in a long time. I was liking this new Brooke. Kai was definitely doing something for her with all his touching. She was surprising me more every week.

When we finished and she curled up against me, I lay in the dark thinking about the session, about Kai's hands on her jaw, on her ribs, on her lower stomach just above her hips, his fingers working into her muscles, his ear pressed to her chest.

She'd sounded better than ever, that was undeniable. Whatever Kai was doing was working, was helping her access parts of her voice she hadn't been able to reach before.

I was clearly benefiting from it too, based on how she'd been with me in bed. So what was there to object to?

By the third session the routine was fully established. I drove us downtown once a week, parked on the same street, walked to the warehouse, sat in the control room while Kai worked with Brooke in the booth, the recording always running.

This session they were working on a new song. Brooke kept struggling with one particular vocal line, her voice sounding tight and restricted no matter how many times she tried it.

Kai had her run through it maybe six or seven times, trying different approaches through the talkback, breathing exercises, posture adjustments, having her move around the booth, having her sit down, stand up. Nothing quite broke through whatever was blocking her.

Finally he muted the talkback and came back to the control room, sitting in the chair next to mine, listening to the playback with a thoughtful expression.

"She's got major performance anxiety on this one," he said. "You can hear it, all jaw and throat tension. She's strangling the note before it even comes out."

"Is there something that helps with that?" I asked.

He was quiet for a moment, then turned to look at me directly.

"I can do something. It's going to sound weird when I say it, but I think it might work."

"Okay," I said, waiting.

"Basically I just want to kiss her. Just a quick kiss, force her facial muscles to open up and relax, and drop the performance anxiety with something else. It can be a physical reset, get her out of her head and back into her body. Like fully."

My stomach dropped, sudden and sharp, but Kai's expression was completely casual, like he'd suggested she drink some water.

"You're going to be cool with that?" he asked. "I won't do it if you're not comfortable, but it might work."

I felt trapped between two responses, say no and be the insecure boyfriend holding Brooke back, or say yes and give permission for another man to kiss my girlfriend.

The way he explained it made it sound clinical, like it was another tool in the toolkit, no different from adjusting the microphone position.

"If it helps her sing better," I heard myself say, "yeah, okay."

"Cool," Kai said, standing up. "I already explained it to her last night, she's comfortable with it."

"Last night?"

"Oh yeah, we were texting a little bit. You didn't know?"

"I was out."

He nodded as he went into the booth and the red light clicked on while his eyes were still on mine. I watched through the glass as he approached Brooke at the microphone.

"So that tension you're feeling," I heard him say through the monitors, "I think it's time to try."

"Yeah, he's okay with it?" Brooke said, looking uncertain.

"I told him I'm basically going to kiss you, to force your facial muscles to relax, to get you out of your head. A physical reset."

Brooke's eyes went wide and she immediately looked toward the glass, toward me. I could see the question on her face even from here.

Kai said something else I couldn't hear, his voice lower, and then he looked at the glass too, waiting.

Brooke swallowed.

I raised my hand and gave a thumbs up, committing to the choice I'd already made. I saw Brooke take a breath and nod slowly at me.

Kai stepped closer to her, put his hand gently on her jaw, and he kissed her.

It was quick and soft, just a press of his lips to hers, maybe two seconds, before he pulled back.

Brooke's eyes went huge, her face flushed red, her fingers coming up to touch her mouth where he kissed her.

But Kai was already stepping back and gesturing to the microphone.

"Now we try that line again," he said. "Don't think about it now, just sing."

She sang and the difference was immediate and dramatic. Her voice was open and relaxed, the tension completely gone, the note clear and full and exactly what the song needed.

Kai came back to the control room and pulled up the playback. We listened together.

"Hear that?" he said. "Totally different. I knew it would work."

"Yeah," I said, my voice sounding strange to me. "Big difference."

"Let's do a few more takes while she's in this state, and really capture it."

He went back into the booth. Before the next take, he came up to her close again, held her chin in his palm, and he kissed her again, longer this time, maybe for three or four seconds. And she was open to it, fully accepting of it, even reaching up to touch his cheek too, and then she sang, and it was even better.

They did this a few more times, kissing longer and longer each time, then singing, and by the third time, Brooke didn't seem at all shy about it anymore. She didn't touch her mouth after, she seemed to like it, it became part of the process, something they did before takes. She seemed to wait for him to kiss her before they restarted. She even smiled to herself when he came toward her.

The kisses were getting longer too, I noticed, and more involved. Kai's hand remained on her jaw or moving around to the back of her neck, the contact lasting five or six seconds instead of two.

And Brooke, she was leaning her head back, pushing her chest up, bringing her fingers around the back of his neck too.

But the vocal takes were the best she'd done. They were undeniably good. Whatever the technique was, it was working.

When the session ended and we were back in the car, Brooke was quiet, looking out the window instead of talking animatedly the way she usually did after sessions.

"You okay?" I asked after a few minutes of silence.

"Yeah," she said. "Just processing."

"The kissing thing," I said. "Are you okay with that? With what happened?"

She was quiet for a moment, then said, "It seemed weird in front of you at first. But it did help. The singing felt so much easier after." She paused. "And Kai is actually a pretty good kisser, so that helps." She laughed and covered her mouth and glanced at me as though guilty.

She was trying to make light of it, trying to defuse the tension. I forced myself to laugh too.

"Well, good," I said. "As long as it's helping, right?"

"Oh yeah, it definitely helps," she said. "Did you hear how different those takes sounded after? Like night and day."

"Night and day, yeah, you sounded amazing."

"It's okay, though, right?"

"Him kissing you like that?"

"In front of you."

I swallowed. "I mean, you seem to like it."

She blushed. "Yeah, maybe a little," she said and she squirmed in her car seat and looked away. "I kind of like it. What do you think about that?"

"Do you think you should stop?"

"Do you think I should stop?"

She looked at me with wide innocent eyes, as though the whole thing was sitting there for me to say yay or nay to.

"If you like it," I said.

"Are you sure?" She reached over and wrapped her cool hand around my finger.

"It's just for the singing, right?"

"For the singing," she nodded, and she looked long out her own window.

That night she was more passionate in bed than she'd ever been, pulling me to the bedroom the moment we got home, initiating things with an urgency.

She was getting wild with it, vocal and demanding, moving against me with serious energy, and when she came, she was loud and uninhibited, nothing like her usual quiet and controlled release before.

I was thinking about Kai's hand on her jaw, about their mouths together, about the way the kisses had gotten longer each time, about how Brooke had said he was a good kisser with that laugh that didn't quite hide something else in her voice. She said she liked it and I said that was good.

It seemed wrong, but she'd also just been more passionate with me than ever before. Whatever was happening in that studio was clearly affecting her, opening her up in ways that were benefiting me too.

I fell asleep telling myself I'd made the right choice, that I was being the supportive boyfriend by not making things weird with jealousy or insecurity. It was just kissing. And texting, which they seemed to do a lot I didn't know about.

The uncomfortable feeling in my chest was still there, though. I pushed it down, and focused instead on how good the sex had been, on how alive Brooke had become in bed.

Over the next few sessions the kissing became routine, it became another part of the process, something that happened as naturally as Brooke putting on the headphones or Kai adjusting the microphone. They kissed hugged and kissed deeply as soon as we got there.

Then Kai would be at the mixing board with me, listening to a playback. Brooke would glance and grin at him through the glass and he'd grin back at her and they he'd say to me, "Let me just reset her again real quick," and he'd go into the booth, the red light clicking on.

I'd watch through the glass as he approached Brooke and she'd bounce on her feet and together they'd kiss before the next take, her fingers twisting in his top at his sides, pulling him closer against her.

Then he'd come back out, ask her through the talkback if she was ready. "I'm definitely ready," she would say with a grin and a blush. He looked down at me in the gaming chair. "I think Brooke is ready, you think she's ready?"

"She seems ready, yeah," I said.

We'd record and her voice would sound open and relaxed, exactly like he said it would be. It was hard to argue with what was going on right in front of me.

Because it worked. That was the undeniable truth. So I sat and watched it happen and got used to it, even, though something in my chest felt wrong every single time.

Half the time it was Brook who'd say she "needs a reset I think." They both laughed about it, both of them glancing at me. The kisses got longer with each session. What started as two-second pecks became three seconds, then five, then longer, Kai's hand on her jaw or the back of her neck under her hair, Brooke leaning into it more each time. Her hands roamed on him as much as his roamed on her.

"I need you to really commit to the release," I heard him tell her one session through the monitors. "Let the tension fully drop. Don't hold anything back from it." He was behind her rubbing her shoulders and neck deeply.

And she didn't hold back. I watched her turn into him, lean into the kiss, watched her body relax against his, watched it stop being a quick technical thing and become something that looked less clinical with each passing week. When she sang, it was directly to him through the glass.

One session Kai forgot to mute the talkback after a take and I heard him say to her, his voice warm and intimate, "You're getting so much better at letting go. I can really hear it in your voice. You're finding your voice now."

"So you call it," Brooke said. Her voice sounded different than when she talked to me, warmer somehow, more open. She was aroused by him. It was obvious.

Kai realized the talkback was still on and muted it quickly, caught my eye through the glass and grinned, gave me a thumbs up like we were teammates working together to help Brooke improve.

Between sessions Kai and Brooke texted more than ever. It was clearly more than just arranging times. I'd see notifications pop up on her phone when we were having dinner or watching TV, or late at night, her screen lighting up with messages, and when I asked about it, she said they were discussing song ideas, concepts for what to work on next.

"He's really invested in the project," she said one night, typing a response. "He just wants to make sure he and I are using the studio time as efficiently as possible. I mean, you're there too, right?"

I nodded but didn't push it. I noticed the texts came at odd hours sometimes, late at night or early in the morning. Brooke would smile at her phone in a way that made my stomach twist.



One Thursday Brooke said her and Kai had been texting and he wanted to know if she could come in for a late session, that time had opened up in the studio and they could really focus and get some good work done.

I had an early morning meeting the next day, a presentation I'd been preparing for, and I said, "Can you reschedule? Or go another night? I can't really drive you this late, I need to be up at six."

"He wants me tonight," she said, reading the message again. "Something about the energy being right, wanting to capture it with me while it's there."

"Can you go another time when I can drive you?"

"I can Uber," she said, looking up from her phone. "There and back. It's fine."

I felt uncomfortable with the whole thing, her going alone into that neighborhood at night, going to that studio with just Kai there and no one else watching, but I didn't know how to say it without sounding controlling or jealous or like I didn't trust her.

"He said he can meet me outside."

"If you're comfortable with it," I said.

"I totally am," she said, already texting him back, smiling. "It's good for me to get as much practice as I can with him."

She left around eight-thirty, dressed nicer than she usually did for sessions, makeup done, hair styled. I watched her Uber pull away from our apartment and went to bed trying not to think about what was going to be happening in that studio.

I couldn't sleep. I lay there checking my phone, watching the time pass, nine, nine-thirty, ten, eleven, eleven-thirty.

She texted around eleven-forty-five that she was heading home. I turned off my light and pretended to be asleep when I heard her come in just after midnight.

She took a shower, not her usual thing at night, and got ready for bed quietly in the bathroom, slipping under the covers next to me. I could feel the energy radiating off her, could sense something different in the way she moved.

"How'd it go?" I asked, my voice rough like I'd just woken up.

"Really good," she said. "We got so much done. The session was really productive."

"What did you work on?"

"Just... some new material. Kai had some ideas he wanted to try. It's hard to explain."

She wouldn't give me details, wouldn't elaborate, and something about the way she said it made my stomach tighten with a feeling I didn't want to examine.

I waited for her to initiate sex the way she'd been doing after every session for weeks now, waited for her to turn to me with that passion and energy she'd been bringing home.

But she didn't this time, she just said goodnight and rolled onto her side facing away from me. Her breathing slowed within minutes.

For the first time in weeks she went to sleep, no sex, no intimacy, just immediate unconsciousness like she was exhausted. Or satisfied. Or both.

I lay awake in the dark listening to her breathe and thinking about the session I hadn't been there for, about what had happened in that studio with no one watching, about why she wouldn't tell me details, about why she'd come home energized but hadn't wanted to touch me.

Something had changed. Some line had been crossed during that solo session that hadn't been crossed when I was there in the control room watching through the glass.

The kissing had been contained when I could see it, when Kai came back to the mixing board after and we worked together like colleagues.

But tonight there'd been no one for him to come back to, no me watching through glass. It was just the two of them alone in that studio for three hours, Brooke coming home flushed and energized but unwilling to talk about it and possibly too satisfied to need anything from me.

I woke up for my six AM alarm. Brooke was still sleeping deeply. I got ready for work quietly and left her there and drove to my meeting thinking about what I'd possibly let happen.

The uncomfortable feeling in my chest had grown into something I couldn't ignore anymore, something that sat heavy and undeniable, but I still didn't know what to do about it.

I'd established a pattern of saying yes, of being supportive, of not making things weird with jealousy or possessiveness. I didn't know how to break that pattern now without admitting I'd been uncomfortable all along, without revealing that I'd been lying to her and to myself about being okay with any of this.

I went to my meeting and gave my presentation and went through my day. I didn't text Brooke about the late night session, didn't ask for details, didn't push for information she clearly didn't want to give.

I let it sit there between us, this thing that had happened that we weren't going to talk about. I went home that evening and we made dinner together and watched TV and went to bed. Everything seemed normal except for the weight of what we weren't saying.

The next session I made sure to come along, told Brooke I'd cleared my schedule even though I hadn't really. I just didn't want her going to the studio alone again, didn't want another night of not knowing what happened in that booth.

I didn't say that to her. I just said I'd drive like normal.

We got to the warehouse and climbed the stairs and Kai greeted us the same as always, friendly and casual. They appeared not different around each other. We went through the routine, Brooke going into the booth, me in the gaming chair behind the mixing board, recording starting automatically.

"Tonight I want us to work on that new song," Kai said, pulling it up on the computer screen. "It needs real emotional vulnerability, real rawness. We were developing a technique for accessing that the other night," he said. "Too bad you couldn't be here."

"It's okay," I said, watching through the glass as he went into the booth and closed the door behind him.

The red light clicked on and Kai approached Brooke at the microphone.

"So we're going to do some of those connection exercises we worked on that night, before each take," he said to her through the monitors. "It'll help you access the emotion the song needs. The vulnerability. Just like we practiced, right?"

"The techniques, yeah," Brooke said, nodding and glancing through the glass at me. "Here though? Now?" she said much more softly, privately to him.

"You have to trust me on this. Come here, away from the mic."

She grinned and seemed to twist her mouth to keep from laughing. He made her stand facing him in the center of the booth so they were maybe a foot apart. He put his hands on her shoulders and she put hers on his.

"Now we just breathe together. You match my breathing. Just look at me. Don't worry about..." he stopped.

I watched through the glass as they stood breathing in sync together, their chests rising and falling at the same time, maintaining direct eye contact the whole way, their hands on each other's shoulders. It looked intimate in a way that made my chest tighten and my throat close.

They stayed like that for maybe thirty seconds, just breathing deeply and slow and looking at each other, before Kai moved his hands from her shoulders to her face, cupping her jaw with both hands. He leaned in and kissed her.

It was a real kiss, full and long, his mouth moving against hers. I watched Brooke kiss him back, too, watched her lean into it. This went on with the spotlight falling on them for a long period.

When they finally pulled apart Kai said something to her I couldn't hear through the glass, something quiet and meant just for her. She nodded, her chest heaving, and then they were kissing again. Her eyes shot sideways to the studio window but Kai gently guided her face back to his.

This kiss was deeper and longer, Kai's hand moving to the back of her neck, his fingers sliding into her hair. Brooke's hands went from his shoulders to his waist, pulling him closer against her.

"Don't be scared," I heard him say.

"But he's..." she started, but he swallowed her words with another kiss.

They made out like that in the center of the booth like a real couple, like people who did this all the time, their hands moving over each other's backs and necks and into each other's hair, pulling, their bodies pressing tighter together. It went on for what felt like forever. It seemed to me excessive for the purposes of resetting her "feelings" for a take on a new song.

I sat frozen in the chair watching through the glass, unable to move or speak or do anything except witness it. The red sound studio light was on.

Finally they separated, both breathing hard. Kai, with his hand around her waist, guided Brooke up to the microphone and he came back to the control room.

He sat in the chair next to me and pressed record, and through the monitors he said, "Now do what you do."

Brooke looked long at him with a creeping grin, and then she began to sing. Her voice was incredible, raw and vulnerable and emotional in a way I'd never heard from her, every word dripping with real feeling, with something deep and honest that made the song come alive.

When she finished Kai played back the take and we listened together. He turned to me with this satisfied expression on his face.

"That's her," he said. "That's what we've been trying to unlock all this time. That's her actual voice, that's what we worked on that late night together."

I couldn't speak, my throat too tight, so I just nodded.

"Let's do it again," Kai said into the talkback. "Same process."

He went back into the booth and they did their connection exercise again, standing close, breathing together, hands on each other's body. And then they made out for even longer this time, Kai's hands roaming her back, Brooke's fingers in his hair, tugging, their bodies completely pressed together.

Then she sang and the take was just as good, just as raw and emotional and real.

This happened four more times over the course of the two-hour session. It was this new connection exercise of their's, which was really just them making out like lovers, then singing, then Kai coming back to the control room and he and I listening to the playback together like colleagues working on a project.

My hand stayed on the record button like Kai told me to, making sure everything was being captured, documenting every kiss, every take, every moment of my girlfriend making out with another man in the name of her music.

When the session finally ended and we were back in the car, Brooke fell quiet, looking out the passenger window, her hair messed up from Kai's hands, her lips swollen.

"You good?" I asked as I drove us out of the neighborhood.

"Yeah," she said quietly. "That kind of work is just really... intense for an artist."

I wanted to ask what had happened during the solo session last week, wanted to ask how she felt about the connection exercises, wanted to ask if this was still professional or if it had become something else.

But I didn't. I just drove us home in silence.

That night she was different with me, more demanding than she'd ever been, pulling me toward the bedroom the moment we got inside, telling me exactly what she wanted.

"Fuck me hard, baby," she said, her voice direct and unashamed. "Pull my hair. Don't be gentle with me." It was wild.

I did what she asked, gave her what she wanted, pulled her hair and fucked her rough. She came hard and loud, her voice breaking with sounds that reminded me of how she'd sounded singing after kissing Kai.

Then she rolled over and fell asleep immediately, like she'd gotten what she needed and was done.

I thought about what I'd watched through the glass, about their hands on each other's bodies, about the way they'd looked like a couple, and about how her best singing came right after his mouth had been on hers, about how I'd sat and recorded it all.

Kai texted Brooke the day before the next session. I saw the message on her phone while we were having dinner together.

"Been thinking about a new direction for the next songs," the text said. "They need more edge, more sexuality. You need to embody that energy to really sell it. Dress differently tomorrow, something that makes you feel confident, sexual. Trust me on this."

"What's that about?" I asked, reading over her shoulder.

She didn't realize I was reading it. "He wants me to dress differently for the session. Says it'll help with the performance, with accessing the right energy for the songs."

"What does he mean?"

"More... sexy, I guess?" She looked uncertain. "He says I should embody the sexuality of the songs to sing them right."

The next evening she emerged from our bedroom wearing a dress I'd never seen before, black and fitted, shorter than what she normally wore, with more makeup than usual, and her hair styled instead of just pulled back.

"Is this going to be okay?" she asked, looking self-conscious.

"You look incredible," I said. And she did, she looked stunning in a way that made my stomach knot because I knew she wasn't dressing like that for me.

We drove to the warehouse and when we walked into the studio Kai's reaction was immediate and enthusiastic.

"Oh yeah," he said, looking at Brooke with open appreciation. "That's it. That's exactly the energy you need. You look amazing."

She blushed and smiled. I sat down at the mixing board while Kai led her into the booth, the recording already started.

The red light clicked on and they began with their connection exercise, but it was different this time, more intense.

The kissing was longer and deeper. Kai's hands roamed freely over her body, over the tight dress, exploring her curves, her hips, her waist, her thighs. I watched through the glass and made sure the levels were right, made sure everything was being captured. Like it was my job.

When they finally separated, Kai kept his hands on her hips and said "I want you to sing while I touch you. Like before, but more this time. Really let yourself feel me, let the sexuality come through in your voice."

She nodded and stepped up to the microphone. Kai stood tight behind her with his hands on her hips. She started singing.

"Just relax," he said privately to her.

"It's hard."

"You can do it."

"I'm nervous though."

"That's where I want you. That's what I want in your voice."

She twisted around inside his arms. "You're really crazy, you know that?"

He smirked and kissed her.

She tuned back to the mic and belted it out. His hands moved over her body while she sang, sliding from her hips to her waist, up her sides, across her ribs. I watched through the glass as they traveled down to her bare thighs, over her stomach, higher up the sides of her breasts through the dress. They swayed together. She reached behind herself and covered his hands with hers, traveled her body with him.

Her voice was transforming as she sang, becoming sultry and confident, sensual in a way I'd never heard from her, every word carrying sexual energy.

"That's it," Kai said quietly, his hands still moving over her body. "Feel it. Let it come through you."

Then his hands traveled up and he cupped her breasts through her dress. Brooke kept singing, her voice getting breathy and affected. I sat at the mixing board watching and recording and unable to look away.

At the end of the take, they moved to the couch, visible through the glass, sitting close together with Kai's arm around her, their heads bent

together talking quietly, her legs crossed, his hand trapped between her things, both her hands gripping his forearm.

I could hear their voices through the monitors but couldn't make out the actual words, just the intimate tone of the conversation, the quiet laughter. Neither of them were looking out at me at all. I was nearly forgotten in the control room.

Then they began kissing again. Kai pulled her onto his lap so she was straddling him. They made out like that for several minutes, his hands over her hips and her waist and her back, her hands in his hair, both of them completely engaged with it. It didn't seem to be a warm up or resetting for a take. It seemed to be just straight up making out.

But I only sat watching and recording, my finger on the button, capturing every moment.

When they finally pulled apart and went back to recording, Brooke's voice was even better, more raw and sensual and powerful in a way that was undeniably compelling.

The music they were creating was incredible. It was impossible to deny.

The session continued like that for two full hours, touching, making out on the couch, singing, more caressing, more making out, Brooke transforming in front of my eyes into this sexual person I barely recognized.

When it finally ended and she emerged from the booth, she looked flushed and disheveled, her hair messed up from Kai's hands, her dress wrinkled, her lips swollen from kissing.

In the car she was quiet and distracted, checking her phone constantly, texting Kai while I drove us home.

At home she was different with me, rougher and more demanding than she'd been before.

"Fuck me doggy style from behind," she said as soon as we got to the bedroom, already pulling off her dress. "Pull my hair. Be rough. I need to feel your energy, baby."

I gave her what she wanted, took her from behind with my hand wrapped in her hair. She was vocal and uninhibited, making sounds and saying things she'd never said before.

"Harder!" she demanded. "Don't hold back. Fuck me like you mean it!"

It was the kind of thing Kai would say.

I fucked her hard, I gave her everything I had. She came loud and intensely, her whole body shaking.



Afterward I lay there hating myself for it, for benefiting from what Kai was doing to her, for taking the passion he'd created and pretending it was for me when I knew it wasn't.

But I also couldn't deny that I liked it, I liked this version of her, liked the intensity and the rawness, even though I knew exactly where it came from.

I was addicted to what I was getting while simultaneously hating how I was getting it, trapped in a cycle I didn't know how to break, because breaking it meant losing the best sex I'd ever had, losing the version of her that had emerged.

The music was incredible. Brooke was transforming into the artist she'd always wanted to be. And I was getting a sexual relationship I'd never thought possible with her.

The next session had already been running for three hours, longer than usual. It was past eleven when Kai came out of the booth and sat down next to me at the mixing board.

"We're so close," he said, pulling up the tracks and listening through headphones. "Like really close to finishing the whole EP. I don't want to stop now, when the energy is too good, everything's clicking."

"It's getting pretty late," I said, checking the time on my phone.

"I know, but this is when the best work happens sometimes, you know? When you push past tired into that zone where the real creativity lives." He looked at me. "What if we just keep going? Work through the night if that's what it takes?"

"Tonight?" I said. "Like, all night?"

"Yeah. I mean, you're welcome to stay too, but..." He gestured around the small control room, then toward the booth. "The space is tight, and the couch in there is really only good for one person. And honestly, intensive sessions like this, they work better with fewer people. Fewer distractions, you know? Real art is possible tonight, man."

He wasn't asking me to leave, but the implication was clear. My presence wasn't necessary, might even be getting in the way.

Through the glass I could see Brooke in the booth taking a water break. She must have sensed us talking about her because she looked toward the window with a questioning expression.

Kai hit the talkback button. "Brooke, what do you think about working through the night? Really pushing through and finishing this thing?"

"Tonight?" she said, her voice coming through the monitors.

"Yeah. We're so close. Terrance would head home, we'd just keep working, you and me, crash here if we need to."

She looked through the glass directly at me. I could see the question in her eyes, the request for permission or approval or whatever she needed from me.

I felt the weight of the decision settle heavy on my shoulders. If I said no, I was the boyfriend holding her back from finishing a project she'd invested months of her life in, this thing that had become so important to her. If I said yes, I was giving permission for her to spend the night alone with Kai in this warehouse, in this studio, with no one watching. Again.

"I guess if you want to," I said, trying to keep my voice neutral. "If you think it'll help finish the EP."

"I really do," she said through the monitors. "I really want to do it all tonight."

"Okay," I said, the word feeling heavy in my mouth.

"Awesome," Kai said, grinning. "This is going to be great. We'll get so much done."

I stood up from the mixing board feeling suddenly displaced and unnecessary. Brooke came out of the booth.

"Thank you for understanding," she said, and there was something in her eyes I couldn't read. "I know it's late, I know this is weird."

"Do you need anything? Clothes for tomorrow, toothbrush?"

"Oh," she said, like she hadn't thought that far ahead. "Yeah, that would be really helpful. Could you grab my overnight bag from home?"

"Sure. What do you need?"

She leaned in close and lowered her voice so Kai couldn't hear. "The usual stuff, but also... could you pack some of my nicer underwear? The black set from my top drawer?"

My stomach dropped but I nodded. "What for?"

"If makes me feel, you know... And Kai says I need to really feel that."

I drove home through streets that were starting to empty out, let myself into our apartment that felt too quiet and too dark, and found her overnight bag in the closet.

I packed her toothbrush, face wash, a change of clothes for tomorrow. Then I opened her underwear drawer and looked at the black lace set she'd

asked for, expensive and sexy, something she rarely wore. I put it in the bag with hands that weren't steady.

I drove back to the warehouse, climbed the stairs one more time, and found them already setting up to continue working, Kai at the board making notes, Brooke in the booth doing vocal warmups.

"Thanks man," Kai said when I handed him the bag. "Really appreciate you being cool about this."

"Thank you for being so supportive," Brooke said through the glass. She smiled at me but wouldn't hold my eyes.

Then I left, going back down the stairs and out into the night, and I drove home to our empty apartment.

I tried to sleep but couldn't. I was checking my phone obsessively, watching the hours crawl by.

Midnight. One AM. Two. Three.

I was imagining what was happening in that studio right now, Kai and Brooke alone together all night, the booth with its couch and its intimate lighting, the connection exercises with no one watching.

The black lace underwear I packed for her in her overnight bag.

I gave up on sleep around six and made coffee, sat on the couch with my phone, and a text came just after nine: "Ready for pickup when you are."

I drove back downtown, the neighborhood looking different in Sunday morning light, and when I got to the warehouse and climbed the stairs, Brooke was waiting in the hallway outside the studio.

She looked exhausted and glowing at the same time, her hair messy like she'd just run her fingers through it, wearing jeans and a t-shirt I didn't recognize, probably something of Kai's. It was big on her

"Hey," she said, not looking at me.

"How'd it go?" I asked.

"Amazing. We got so much done. The EP is basically finished. I'm really happy with everything."

In the car she wouldn't make eye contact, just kept looking out the passenger window, and when I asked about the session she kept her answers vague. It went really well, Kai is so talented, she's excited for me to hear the final mixes.

Then she pulled out her phone and showed me photos, professional shots of her at the microphone in the booth, the lighting dramatic, her in

that tight dress from earlier sessions, her looking confident and sensual and like someone I barely recognized.

"Kai took these?" I asked.

"Yeah, last night. For promotion when we release the EP."

That night at home she was different with me, gentler than she'd been lately, almost tender, but there was a distance in it that hadn't been there before, something remote and unreachable.

When I tried to initiate sex after we got into bed, she put her hand on my chest and said quietly, "Maybe not tonight? I'm really exhausted."

It was the first time she'd said no in months, the first time since the sessions had started that she'd turned me down.

I lay there in bed next to her while she fell asleep. I knew with absolute certainty that something had happened during the night that I would never fully know about, something that had changed the fundamental nature of whatever this was between all of us.

She'd spent the night with him, she had worn the black lace I'd packed for her, she had done things I hadn't been there to witness or understand.

Whatever happened had satisfied her enough that she didn't need me tonight, didn't want me, could just turn away and sleep without that desperate edge she'd been carrying home from every session.

I'd crossed a line by saying yes to the overnight, by packing that bag, by driving away and leaving them alone together all night.

But the EP was almost done. The project was nearly complete. Brooke had achieved what she'd set out to do. She had become an artist.

We were back to regular sessions but nothing felt regular anymore, nothing felt the same after that overnight.

The first session back, Brooke showed up in an off-shoulder top and a short skirt, dressed the way Kai had been asking her to dress. I sat at the mixing board while they went into the booth together, the recording starting automatically.

The connection exercises were different now, more overt, no longer containing even the pretense of being purely professional.

Kai's hands slid under her top immediately, touching bare skin, her stomach, her ribs, moving higher while they kissed, even cupping her breasts right in front of me. Brooke wasn't stopping him, she was leaning into it, her own hands exploring his chest, his back, both of them completely comfortable with each other now

They were playful about it too, laughing between kisses, Brooke teasing him, sticking her tongue out when he pulled back to look at her, him grinning and pulling her closer again, both of them enjoying it.

I watched through the glass and kept the recording running, my hands on the controls, making sure everything was being captured.

They weren't even pretending this was just technique anymore. It was just them making out, touching each other, clearly wanting each other, and then singing afterward when they felt like it.

The next session was worse. Kai had Brooke lie down on the couch in the booth. He leaned over her, kissing her neck while his hand slid up her thigh, slow and deliberate. I watched through the glass and heard everything through the monitors.

"You need to feel opened up and vulnerable for this next one," Kai said, his voice low and intimate. "To really access the emotion this song needs."

"Is that so," Brooke breathed with a smile. Her voice was already affected, already changed. Her legs opened wider, her skirt riding up to her hips. "And you're going to open me, are you?" she laughed lightly and snapped her thighs closed when I touched her there.

But his hand kept moving up her thigh, disappearing under her skirt. Brooke gasped, her back arching off the couch.

My hand froze on the mixing board, the recording running, capturing the audio of what I was watching happen.

Kai's hand moved under her skirt and Brooke's breathing changed, got faster and shallower. I could hear the small sounds she was making, sounds I recognized from our own bedroom but had never heard her make for anyone else.

Her body responded to his touch, writhing on the couch, her hips moving with his hand. I sat watching it happen through the glass, watching another man touch my girlfriend intimately. I did nothing.

It went on for maybe five minutes, Kai's hand working under her skirt, Brooke's breathing getting more ragged, her sounds getting louder. I knew exactly what was happening, knew what he was doing to her.

Finally he pulled his hand back and helped her sit up, smoothed her hair with a tenderness that made something twist in my chest. He held her steady as she stood on legs that looked unsteady.

He walked her to the microphone and positioned her there, his hands on her shoulders, and then he leaned in and kissed her neck from behind,

intimate and possessive.

"Now let's capture that feeling right there," he said quietly, his hand cupping her groin,, his voice coming through the monitors warm and close.

She sang and her voice was raw and real and devastating, every word carrying emotion that came directly from what had just happened, from what he'd just done to her body.

It was the best vocal take I'd ever heard her do, undeniably powerful and real. It was good stuff.

When the session ended Brooke emerged from the booth looking flushed and unsteady. She couldn't look at me, wouldn't meet my eyes at all.

In the car she was completely silent, staring out the window. I didn't know what to say and we drove home in a heavy silence.

At home she pulled me toward the bedroom immediately, desperate and urgent in a way that felt almost frantic.

"I need you now," she said, her voice thick with something. "I need it so bad right now."

We had sex and she was almost violent about it, demanding and intense. She came hard, her whole body shaking, screaming loud enough that I knew the neighbors could hear.

But I knew the entire time she was thinking about Kai, about what had happened on that couch, about his hand under her skirt, about the way he'd touched her.

I was just the outlet for desire he'd created, the place to channel energy he'd built up in her.

When she fell asleep after, I lay there thinking about what I'd become, about how I sat at that mixing board session after session watching my girlfriend being touched by another man.

I recorded her pleasure, her responses, her transformation into someone who wanted things from someone else.

The recordings existed now on the hard drive, audio of her gasping, of her breathing changing, of the sounds she made while Kai touched her under her skirt.

But the music. The music was incredible. Brooke was becoming the artist she'd always dreamed of being.

The next session Kai took it further.

I was at the mixing board, running the recording, and through the glass I watched Kai lead Brooke to the couch in the booth.

She was wearing a tight tank top and that short skirt again. Kai laid her down on the couch and leaned over her, kissing down her neck while his hands roamed freely under her clothes with no hesitation, no pretense of asking permission.

His hands slid up under her tank top, touching bare skin, moving over her stomach and ribs, and then he pulled the top off completely, lifted it over her head. Brooke raised her arms to help him.

Her bra came next, unhooked and removed. She was topless in the booth now, visible through the glass. I watched, my body rigid in the chair.

Kai's mouth went to her breasts, kissing them. Brooke's head fell back, a moan coming through the monitors loud and unguarded. She rolled her head to find me, but Kai took her jaw in his hand and rolled her face back.

Her hands were on him now, pulling at his shirt, sliding underneath it to touch his chest and stomach, pushing down toward his waistband. She laughed playful and free and completely uninhibited.

I watched her whole body arch and contort under his mouth and hands, watched her move with desire, watched her become someone I barely recognized.

Kai's hand slid down her stomach to the waistband of her skirt. I could see the lace edge of underwear, black and expensive, something she must have bought without telling me.

His hand disappeared into her underwear and Brooke gasped loud, her back arching hard off the couch. I heard everything through the monitors, heard her breathing get desperate and ragged.

I sat behind the mixing board. I couldn't move, couldn't speak, could barely process what I was watching.

Kai worked her with his hand and I watched her respond completely, watched her hips move against his touch, watched her lose herself entirely in what he was doing to her.

She suddenly hyperventilated and froze, then cried out through the monitors, her whole body shaking, her voice breaking with sounds of pure pleasure that I'd heard hints of before but never like this, never this raw and real and loud.

When she came down Kai held her on the couch, tender and possessive at the same time, stroking her hair, kissing her forehead, whispering things I couldn't hear through the monitors.

Finally he helped her sit up, helped her find her bra and shirt and get dressed again, and then he walked her to the microphone and positioned her there.

"Now sing," he said, standing close behind her. "While you're still feeling it."

She sang and her voice was completely unguarded, vulnerable and sexual and devastating, every word carrying the weight of what had just happened to her body.

The recording was incredible. The best thing she'd ever done, maybe the best thing I'd ever heard anyone do.

When the take finished Kai came back to the control room and sat in the chair next to me, pulled up the audio file and played it back through the monitors.

"That's it," he said. I could hear the satisfaction in his voice. "That's her real voice. Everything we've been working for all these months."

I nodded because I couldn't speak, my throat was too tight, my chest was too full.

We sat listening to the playback together. I could hear everything in her voice, the pleasure, the vulnerability, the complete surrender to what she was feeling.

When the session ended Brooke emerged from the booth shaky and flushed and couldn't meet my eyes. We barely spoke during the drive home.

"Do what he did," she said to me that night. I knew exactly who she meant. "Touch me like that. Make me feel it like that."

I tried to give her what she wanted, tried to replicate what I'd watched through the glass, my hand between her legs, working her the way Kai had worked her.

She came, her voice breaking with a scream, but I knew the entire time I was just a substitute, knew she was thinking about him, channeling her desire for him onto me because I was there and available.

The EP was almost done, just one or two more songs left to finish. Just one or two more sessions. That's what I told myself, like there was an endpoint coming, like this would stop once the music was complete.

But I knew it was a lie. I knew this wasn't really about the music anymore, if it ever had been.

I lay there listening to Brooke breathe and I knew I'd lost her, knew she belonged to Kai now in ways that mattered more than our shared apartment



or our two years together or anything else.

I fell asleep knowing tomorrow I'd probably listen to those recordings again, would hear her voice in the playback, would hear the pleasure Kai had given her.

Kai's text came that morning while we were having breakfast, the message appearing on Brooke's phone: "Last song. Let's finish this thing today."

She showed it to me and I nodded, said I'd drive her. We got ready in silence, the weight of what was coming hanging between us even though neither of us acknowledged it.

We drove downtown one more time, through streets I knew by heart now, past landmarks that had become familiar over months of making the drive. I parked on the same sketchy block where I always parked. We walked to the warehouse together, climbed the stairs to the second floor. Kai was waiting at the studio door with that easy smile, that confidence that had never wavered.

"So this is it," he said as we walked in. "The last vocal for the EP. Let's make it count."

I went to the mixing board and sat in the chair that had become mine, my hands finding the familiar controls, the buttons and faders I'd learned to operate over all these sessions. Brooke and Kai went into the booth together. I watched through the glass as the door closed behind them and the red light clicked on.

There was no pretense this time, no warmup exercises. Kai just approached Brooke and started undressing her, his hands going to the hem of her shirt and lifting it over her head. She raised her arms to help him, complicit and willing.

Her bra came off next, unhooked and slid down her arms, and then he was working on her skirt, the zipper sliding down, the fabric falling to the floor, and finally her underwear, black lace.

She stood there naked in the booth and I watched through the glass as she lay back on the couch without being asked, her body already moving with anticipation. Her hand slid between her legs, touching herself, her hips shifting against her own fingers.

Kai undressed too, pulling his shirt over his head, stepping out of his jeans and boxer briefs. He was naked now too. I could see everything

through the glass, could see him fully erect as he knelt between her legs on the couch.

He put his mouth on her and the sound that came through the monitors was immediate and obscene, Brooke moaning loud and unguarded. I watched her writhe on the couch, watched her hands go to his hair, watched her back arch and her legs spread wider.

The sounds kept coming through the speakers, wet and explicit, her voice filled with gasps and moans. I sat with my hands on the mixing board making sure the levels were right like I had that one job.

After several minutes Kai pulled back and moved up her body. He knelt over her face and Brooke immediately shifted herself down, eager and enthusiastic, taking him in her mouth. I could see it all, could hear the wet sounds and his groans and her humming as she worked on him.

They moved into a 69 position on the couch, both of them giving and receiving at the same time. It was full-on now, nothing held back, just two people completely lost in each other sexually while I sat in the control room behind the glass.

I don't know how long it went on, time had stopped making sense. Eventually Kai pulled away and stood up. He brought Brooke with him, both of them still naked. He positioned her at the microphone.

Then he stood behind her with his arms wrapped around her body, one hand on her breast and the other between her legs, his fingers working on her while she stood at the mic trying to focus. I could see her squirming back against him, could see his cock pressing between her cheeks from behind, hard and ready.

"Sing baby," he said, and his voice came through the monitors intimate and commanding.

She tried, her voice breaking on the first few words. He kept touching her, kept working her with his fingers. Her voice when she sang was incredible, raw and sexual and completely vulnerable, every note carrying the weight of what was happening to her body.

"That's it," Kai said, his mouth near her ear. "Feel it. Let everything come through."

After one full take like that he brought her back to the couch, laid her down. She pulled her legs up without hesitation, her ankles going over his shoulders, completely open to him, offering herself.

He positioned himself between her legs, the head of his cock pressing against her. He looked back over his shoulder through the glass and directly at me.

Our eyes met across the space, him naked between my girlfriend's spread legs, about to fuck her while I watched. He said clearly into the mic, "Complete authenticity for this last song. You good with it?"

My mouth opened and I tried to speak, tried to say something, anything, but no words came out, just silence, just my breath catching in my throat.

Kai waited maybe two seconds and then he took my silence as permission the way he'd been taking my silence as permission for months. He turned back to Brooke and started teasing her with just the tip of his cock, rubbing it against her, sliding it through her wet folds without entering her.

The sounds Brooke made were desperate and out of control, her body writhing on the couch, her hands gripping the cushions. She was begging now, crying out "Please, and I need it !" and "Kai please fuck me!" her voice breaking

He kept teasing her, kept making her wait, kept her right on the edge. Her whole body was twisting with need, with desire that was completely visible, completely undeniable.

Finally he pushed inside her, slow and easy. Brooke's cry came through the monitors loud and broken and ecstatic, a sound of pure relief and pleasure. I watched him enter her, watched him fill her completely, watched my girlfriend take another man inside her body. I could see her flesh fold around his length, coat him in her wetness.

He started moving on her and she was moaning out loud with every thrust, her voice careless and wild. He fucked her for several minutes with her legs over his shoulders. I could see everything through the glass, could see him moving in and out of her, could see her face twisting with pleasure.

Then he pulled out and flipped her over, positioned her on her hands and knees. He entered her from behind, his hands on her hips pulling her back onto him. Brooke was alternately moaning and laughing, making sounds that were joyful and sexual at the same time, and completely free.

She was teasing him too, pushing back against him, looking over her shoulder at him and saying things I could hear through the monitors, dirty things, demanding things, telling him harder and deeper and don't stop. She reached to grip his thigh behind her.

They fucked like that for a long time, switching positions multiple times, Kai completely in control, directing her body, telling her what to do. She obeyed immediately, gave him everything he asked for.

Finally he had her straddle him. She rode him facing the glass, facing me, but her eyes were closed, her head thrown back, lost in sensation, her hands on his chest and her hips moving in rhythm, taking him deep.

She was completely transformed from the shy reserved girl I'd started dating, was loud and confident and demanding, taking her pleasure without hesitation or embarrassment.

Kai looked past her at me and said through the speaker, "Terrance, turn up the gain on the ambient mic. I want to capture the room."

I did what he told me, adjusted the levels, made sure everything was being recorded. He nodded approval. While my girlfriend fucked him with wild abandon.

"Now sing," he said to Brooke, his hands on her hips guiding her movements on him. "Sing the last song. Sing while you're riding me. Let's capture this."

And she did, she sang the final song of the EP while fucking him, her voice breaking and soaring, the melody intertwining with her moans, the lyrics punctuated by her high pitched gasps. I recorded it all, my hands steady on the controls, making sure the audio was and balanced.

It was beautiful genuinely artistic, her voice layered over the sounds of their bodies, the rhythm of her hips matching the beat of the song, everything coming together into something that transcended just music or just sex and became bigger. I wasn't blind to the genius of it.

They kept going though. I could see Brooke getting close, could see her movements becoming more erratic, less controlled. Kai said he was going to come and she said yes, inside, please, I want to feel you come inside me. He thrust up into her one final time.

She came at the same time, her orgasm hitting her full force while he filled her. Her voice rose in a sound that was part moan, part song, part sob, something completely raw and real that came from the deepest part of her.

They stayed like that for a long moment, Brooke collapsed forward onto his chest, both of them breathing hard. I sat in the control room with the recording still running, capturing their breathing, their whispered words, the intimate silence after.

Eventually they separated and started dressing, slowly and carefully, helping each other find clothes scattered around the booth, intimate and tender in their movements, like lovers who'd done this before.

Kai came to the control room when he was dressed and sat in the chair next to me. He pulled up the audio files and started playing them back. He didn't mention that he just fucked my girlfriend. He didn't behave much differently at all.

The final song came through the speakers with Brooke's vocals layered over her own earlier takes and everything else, her voice woven into the sounds of sex, her moans becoming part of the melody, the rhythm of their bodies matching the percussion, all of it blending together into something that was genuinely art, genuinely beautiful despite or because of how it was created.

"This is good," Kai said, looking at the waveforms on the screen, at the visual representation of what we'd just captured. "This is what we make together, her and I. I'm really glad you were here for it."

He said it like I'd been part of the creative process, like my role at the mixing board made me a collaborator rather than only a witness. And maybe he was right, maybe by recording it all, by making sure everything was captured perfectly, I had been creating this with them.

The EP was finished, months of work, dozens of sessions, all leading to this final song, this final recording.

We left the studio together, the three of us. Kai locked up while Brooke and I waited in the hallway, and then we said goodbye and I drove Brooke home through afternoon traffic, neither of us speaking.

At home she was gentle with me, almost sad, moving around our apartment with a quietness that felt like grief or guilt or both. When we got into bed that night I reached for her and she took my hand and held it but said she was tired, not tonight.

"Kinda sore," she said meekly.

We lay there in the dark not touching beyond our hands. I knew everything had changed, knew she was different and we were different and the relationship was different, knew that whatever we'd been before this summer we weren't that anymore.

After her breathing slowed down and I knew she was asleep, I got up and went to the living room with my phone. I pulled up the recording app

where all the session files had synced automatically, hundreds of audio files organized by date and I started listening.

I listened to her moaning, to her begging, to her singing while Kai fucked her, to every sound she'd made, every moment I'd captured over all these months.

I'd documented the complete loss of her, had the recordings to prove exactly when and how it happened, had made sure every file was saved and backed up and labeled properly so I could find any moment I wanted, could listen to any session, could hear the progression from innocent vocal exercises to this final recording of her being fucked so hard hile singing.

The EP was finished and Brooke was completely transformed. I sat in the dark living room listening to recordings of my girlfriend with another man. I thought about all the choices I'd made, all the moments I could have said no and didn't, all the silences I'd let speak for me.

In the morning we woke up and we didn't talk about it. We made coffee in our usual routine, sat at the kitchen table in silence, the elephant in the room so huge we both worked around it.

Then Brooke's phone buzzed with a text and she picked it up and read it and said plainly, "Kai wants me to come down to the studio. Says there's a couple things he wants to fix on the final mix. When can I go?"

Not if she should go. Not asking permission to go. Just when.

I looked at her across the table and I knew then it wasn't over, knew the EP being finished didn't mean the sessions would stop. I knew Kai would keep finding reasons for her to come to the studio and she would keep going and I would keep saying yes.

"Whenever you want," I heard myself say.

She nodded and started texting back immediately. I sat with my coffee knowing I'd say yes again next time too, knowing I'd drive her there again if she asked, knowing I'd sit at that mixing board again and watch and record whatever came.

Because that's what I'd become. That's what months of small choices and small silences had turned me into.

I was the person who always said yes, who couldn't stop it even now when there was nothing left to protect, nothing left to lose.

We met at the cafe this time. Brooke sat down beside Kai and threw her arms around his neck and kissed him deeply and long on the mouth while I

went to order our coffees. And his hand came down on her lap and the rocked their foreheads together and laughed.

Even when I came back to the table, she carried on with him down in that neighborhood the way she carried on with me anywhere else, with all that new energy, the confidence and carelessness and freedom.

I loved the new Brooke. I learned to take Kai's Brooke with it.